

Session 27: Participation

Key Takeaways

- The construction of the tabernacle and its rituals call for exact obedience.
- The full community participates in the crafting of the tabernacle, its ritual objects, and the priestly garments.
- With the tabernacle built, Israel is poised to rectify a problem that has existed since humans were exiled from the garden of Eden.

Literary Function of Exodus 35-40

The final chapters of Exodus mark the fulfillment of YHWH's instructions to Moses in chapters 25-31. This section, together with the earlier chapters on the tabernacle instructions, frames the gold calf incident and leads up to the climax of the book—God's presence in the community.

Building a Tent for God

These chapters present three speeches from Moses to the community.

Sabbath Reminder (Exod. 35:1-3)

Moses begins by reminding the people about the centrality of the Sabbath, and that doing God's work does not cancel the Sabbath. God's work must be done in God's way.

Commands About Community Participation in Construction (Exod. 35:4-29)

The second speech centers on the call for the community to participate. The entire community responded to the call, and everyone who was willing participated.

Offerings were voluntary but specific ([Exod. 25:1-9](#), [35:1-9](#)), and both men and women responded ([Exod. 35:22-24](#), [29](#)). Leaders contributed gemstones and ingredients for oil and incense ([Exod. 35:27-28](#)), and the people gave more than enough ([Exod. 36:3-7](#)).

All who were skilled contributed, with the text specifically calling out the contribution of skilled women who spun yarn ([Exod. 35:25-26](#)).

Appointment of Bezalel and Oholiab to Design and Teach (Exod. 35:30-36:7)

The final speech of this section highlights the special appointment of Bazalel and Oholiab. They are filled with the Spirit of God for wisdom, understanding, knowledge, and skill in an expansive range of crafts: metalwork, engraving gemstones, woodworking, artistic crafts, embroidery, and weaving.

Obedience to God's Instructions at Sinai

Exodus 39:42-43 NIV

⁴² The Israelites had done all the work just as the LORD had commanded Moses. ⁴³ Moses inspected the work and saw that they had done it just as the LORD had commanded. So Moses blessed them.

Theological Function of Exodus 35-40

The fulfillment of the tabernacle construction sets up a resolution to the alienation from God in [Genesis 3](#). It marks Israel as the community where YHWH has chosen to dwell, and it ensures the success of Israel's future as long as they maintain proper worship and live in obedience to covenant stipulations.

Reflection Question

What can we learn from the example of full community participation in the construction of the tabernacle?